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Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Park, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton

House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Sala,

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Tele: 041-6177; Int'l In: Fax: 28472178; Cable:

Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:

22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharal Nehru Road,

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• 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind: White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;

Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

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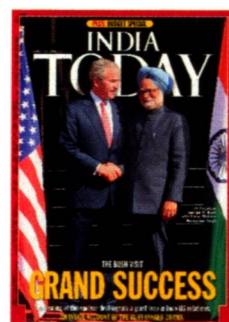
There was a telling moment on the day the prime minister made his speech in Parliament on India's nuclear agreement with the United States. The MPs, who had been shouting slogans in the Lok Sabha against the deal, were later confronted by a TV news channel. They were asked individually about the key aspects of the deal and all expressed ignorance. That is symbolic of the controversy the issue is embroiled in. For the Left, America is like a red rag. The BJP, which is chronically confused, is opposing it in a desperate move to destabilise the Government when it should be taking credit for starting the dialogue with Washington rather than opposing it.

Politically, the tension has heightened. The Left is making threatening noises of withdrawing support or if a vote of no-confidence is provoked by this issue, the UPA Government will not survive. Despite that, Manmohan Singh has taken an unusually aggressive stance. He has staked his reputation—and his Government—on pushing the deal through and believes it is in India's strategic and economic interests to do so. The nuclear deal is not going to win his party any votes. I think he strongly believes this is going to be the one biggest legacy of his premiership. I agree with him. I am not a nuclear expert, like millions of my countrymen, but I know that the main opposition to this is coming from the Left whose ideology has been consigned to the dustbin of history and their 59 MPs do not represent the will of the people. They have crippled the economic reform process of this country and should not be allowed to derail a historic agreement which officially recognises India as a nuclear weapons power by the world's only superpower and not be treated as a pariah anymore. Besides, it also helps India solve its horrendous power crisis by increased use of nuclear energy.

Our cover story is a comprehensive analysis of all the aspects of the nuclear agreement and its political and strategic ramifications. While our political bureau has spoken to leaders of the Left and BJP on the issues that underline their opposition to the deal, Managing Editor Raj Chengappa, our in-house nuclear expert, had also spoken in private to the prime minister on an earlier occasion and we have obtained permission to reveal key aspects of that conversation.

This is clearly a defining moment in terms of the relationship between the Congress and the Left as well as India and the US. It will be nothing short of a tragedy if India's growing global clout and profile is damaged because of ideological straight jackets and political opportunism. I believe this agreement is a rare moment of history brought about by fortuitous circumstances and some audacious leadership. If we miss this chance now, the generations to come will justifiably curse us.

Aron Purie
(Aron Purie)



Our March 2006 cover